

Talk 4: Boundaries, Secrets & Staying Safe

Ages 6–8

Introduction

Hi, and welcome to Bright Talks.

As parents, many of us want our children to grow up feeling confident, safe, and comfortable coming to us when something doesn't feel right.

As children grow, however, their world begins to grow too.

They're spending more time at school, with friends, at activities, and around trusted adults outside the home. And while that growing independence is a healthy part of childhood, it also gives us an opportunity to strengthen something we've been teaching from the very beginning:

Your body deserves respect, your boundaries matter, and you can always ask for help.

Today, we're going to talk about helping children recognize their boundaries, understand the difference between secrets and surprises, identify trusted adults, and know what to do when a situation leaves them feeling uncomfortable or confused.

Boundaries Grow With Them

When children were younger, boundaries may have sounded simple:

"You don't have to give someone a hug if you don't want to."

At six, seven, and eight, we can begin expanding that conversation.

Boundaries aren't only about physical touch.

They're also about personal space, privacy, words, play, and situations that make us uncomfortable.

Maybe a friend won't stop wrestling after your child says they're done.

Maybe someone keeps teasing them after they've asked them to stop.

Maybe another child wants to show them something that makes them uncomfortable.

These everyday situations give children opportunities to practice recognizing and communicating their boundaries.

You can remind them:

"If something doesn't feel right, you can speak up, step away, and find an adult you trust."

Helping Children Use Their Voice

Knowing they have a boundary is one thing.

Knowing how to communicate it is another.

That's why practicing simple phrases at home can be so helpful.

"Please stop."

"I don't like that."

"I need some space."

"I'm going to tell an adult."

Children don't need the perfect words.

They need to know that they're allowed to use their voice.

And we can reinforce that lesson in everyday family life by listening when they communicate a reasonable boundary to us.

When children see that their words matter at home, they're learning how to use those words when we're not there.

Secrets and Surprises

This age is also a good time to talk about the difference between secrets and surprises.

A surprise is something we're keeping quiet for a little while because eventually someone will find out like a birthday present or a special celebration.

But children should never feel responsible for keeping something hidden because someone tells them they'll get in trouble, makes them feel afraid, or asks them not to tell their parents.

Especially when it involves their body, touching, inappropriate pictures, or something that made them uncomfortable.

You might tell your child:

"No one should ask you to keep something from me that makes you feel scared, worried, or uncomfortable. You can always tell me even if someone told you not to."

And then give them one more reassurance:

"You won't be in trouble for telling me."

That can be incredibly important for a child to hear.

Who Are Your Safe Adults?

As children become more independent, they also need to know who they can turn to when you aren't nearby.

Sit down together and identify a few trusted adults in their world.

Maybe it's a grandparent.

A teacher.

A coach.

A relative.

A trusted adult from church or another activity.

Instead of only saying, *"Find an adult,"* help your child know which adults you trust and why.

You can even ask:

"If you were at school and needed help, who could you talk to?"

"What about soccer practice?"

"What if you couldn't reach me?"

These aren't conversations meant to make children afraid.

They're simply giving them a plan.

Preparation creates confidence.

When Something Doesn't Feel Right

Sometimes children won't know exactly why a situation feels uncomfortable.

That's okay.

They don't have to prove that something is wrong before asking for help.

Teach your child that if something feels confusing, uncomfortable, or unsafe, they can:

Speak up. Step away. Tell a trusted adult.

And if the first adult doesn't understand or doesn't help?

Tell another trusted adult.

Keep telling until someone listens.

This isn't about teaching children that everyone around them is dangerous.

It's about teaching them that they never have to handle an uncomfortable situation alone.

A Christian Perspective

As Christians, we believe every person is created in the image of God and deserves dignity, care, and respect.

That includes our children.

Teaching boundaries isn't teaching children to fear others. It's helping them understand that they have value and that other people do too.

We can teach children to respect someone else's *"no"* while also knowing that their own *"no"* matters.

We can teach kindness without requiring silence.

And we can teach respect for adults while helping children understand that if an adult ever asks them to do something unsafe, inappropriate, or secretive, they can always come to us.

Key Takeaway

As your child's independence grows, their confidence and voice can grow with it.

Help them remember: Speak up. Step away. Tell a trusted adult.

And perhaps most importantly:

They can always tell *you*.

Even if they're embarrassed.

Even if they broke a rule.

Even if someone told them not to.

Even if they aren't quite sure what happened.

The goal isn't for your child to know exactly what to do in every possible situation.

It's for them to know they never have to navigate those situations alone.

Wrapping Up

As we finish today's lesson, remember that body safety isn't about raising fearful children.

It's about raising children who know their boundaries, recognize their value, use their voice, and know where to turn when they need help.

Practice these conversations during calm, everyday moments.

Ask questions.

Listen carefully.

And remind your child often:

"Whatever happens, you can always come to me."

Because every time we respond with calmness, honesty, and love, we're building the trust they'll need as their world continues to grow.

And that brings us to our final talk.

In *Keeping the Door Open*, we'll bring everything we've learned together and explore how to protect that trust as your child moves toward the preteen years so that as their questions get bigger, their willingness to come to you grows right alongside them.

We'll see you in the next lesson.

